



OFF-SIDE

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REMEMBERING BRIAN GLANVILLE, INDIA'S WINDOW TO THE BEAUTIFUL GAME

Brian Glanville, the renowned football writer, opened India's eyes to English football through *Sportstar*. A tribute to **a voice that spanned generations.**

In the '80s and '90s, long before European football became a midnight obsession in India, Brian Glanville's weekly column in *Sportstar* was our only window into the English game. It brought us a world we were not part of but very much wanted to understand. The legendary football writer died on May 16, aged 93.

Brian, already a leading figure in English football writing — through his work for *The Sunday Times* and *World Soccer* — told us about the improbable implosion of Kevin Keegan-managed Newcastle United in the 1995–96 season, when it squandered a 12-point January lead to lose the English title. He brought to us the stories of Fergie's Fledglings; the wonder years of Arsene Wenger at his beloved Arsenal. And he never shied away from criticising FIFA ("Fifty ideas every day, 51 of them bad," he'll write often), the Premier League (the "Greed is Good League" for Brian), or the growing money-mindedness that engulfed the game.

Getting the maverick, celebrated Englishman to pen a column for an Indian magazine seemed improbable in 1978, though he had sporadically written for *Sports & Pastime* (*Sportstar*'s predecessor) in the 1950s. **Brian's acerbic, no-nonsense approach soon brought him many fans in the country, as he opened our eyes to a thrilling, unforgiving world of football that, until then, had remained out of reach.**

In his early years, Brian would ring up a copy-taker to dictate his long reports — no drafts, no notes — amid the chaos and frenzy of a noisy football stadium. Even as the century turned, he filed his pieces the old-fashioned way: typed on a battered Olivetti Lettera typewriter that resented the relentless work he forced upon it. It was then faxed across continents — from London to *The Hindu*'s wires desk in Chennai — and retyped by whichever rookie was lowest in the newsroom food

chain, much like the forward short-leg fielder in cricket. (When I joined *Sportstar* in 2008, it was almost always me.)

With the ink fading and half the letters missing, you stared, guessed, and tried rewriting. When stuck, you called Brian at his home. Landline, late night, via *The Hindu*'s switchboard operator. Brian cleared up your doubts in less than a minute, and then — generously, and at great expense to *Sportstar*'s promoters — spent another 30 reminiscing about Walter Winterbottom, Bobby Moore and Alf Ramsey, oblivious to the mounting international call rates.

Brian's big break came in 1958 when he covered the World Cup for *The Sunday Times* in Sweden. The very young English writer was bewitched by an even younger Pele. "Playing just off his centre-forward, astonishingly and precociously cool under pressure, acrobatic, dangerous in the air despite being only 5 foot 8 inches tall, he scored three times in the semifinal against France, two unforgettable goals in the Final, one with right foot, one with head, in the Stockholm decider against the hosts, Sweden," he wrote in *Sportstar*.

Brian went on to cover every subsequent World Cup for the next 44 years. For him, age was never an impediment. He was a regular in the press box in England even a few years ago, and his last published work — an obituary of Northern Ireland and Aston Villa footballer Peter McParland — appeared in *The Guardian* on May 5.

A prolific writer, he penned more than 20 books, not all on football. His 'The Story of the World Cup' remains one of the finest accounts of the tournament ever written. And as a turbulent World Cup approaches next year in the USA, Canada, and Mexico, it is hard to believe Brian won't be there to critique it with his usual bluntness.